SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #11 · COMMUNITY AND NEIGHBORHOOD

“What other people think of me is what matters most.”

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Where it often comes from

In close communities, reputation can feel like survival. Gossip, church talk, and neighborhood watchfulness teach us to monitor how we look to others. Social media has widened that audience. We learn to adjust ourselves to be accepted and fear being talked about.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks, “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?” Proverbs says, “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high.” God told Samuel, “Man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.” Jesus warned about doing good “to be seen by men.” Proverbs adds that “a good name is more desirable than great riches,” which means character matters, but it is built by integrity, not by managing impressions. The final opinion that matters is God’s.

> *“The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high”* (Proverbs 29:25).

Also see

> “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ” (Galatians 1:10).

> “A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold” (Proverbs 22:1).

> “The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?” (Psalm 118:6).

> “Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us” (1 Peter 2:12).

Common self-statements

- If people think badly of me, I am ruined.
- I have to manage how I come across.
- Their opinion decides my worth.
- I cannot stand being talked about.
- I must keep up appearances.
- I have to please everyone.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know what others think.
- Spotlight effect: Believing everyone is watching and judging me.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must always be approved.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling exposed and concluding that I am judged.

Challenging questions

- Whose opinion do I fear most, and why?
- What have I done to win approval that did not feel like me?

- What does a good name actually rest on?
- What does Scripture say about the fear of man?
- What would change if I cared most about God's view?
- What is one place I can be more honest?

Truth summary

> A good name is built by integrity, not by managing impressions. The fear of man is a snare, and God's view of me is what matters most. I can live honestly and let my character speak.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Pride
- Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Humility
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "What other people think of me is what matters most"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What other people think of me is what matters most." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose opinion do I fear?
- ☐ What do I do to win approval?
- ☐ What does a good name rest on?
- ☐ What does God think?
- ☐ Where can I be honest?
- ☐ What will I do differently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God sees the heart.
- ☐ A good name comes from integrity.
- ☐ I seek God's approval first.
- ☐ I do not have to please everyone.
- ☐ The Lord is on my side.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 29:25**
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Proverbs 22:1**
  "A good name is more desirable than great riches; favor is better than silver and gold."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Honest, not impressive: Each week, note one time you chose honesty over impression.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 29:25 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I trust the Lord, so I am set securely on high.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the audience. Write whose opinions you fear most.
- [ ] Test the fear. Note what people actually say or do.
- [ ] Choose integrity. Do one thing because it is right, not because it is seen.
- [ ] Pray Psalm 118:6. Say it before a hard moment.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What other people think of me is what matters most": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Integrity chosen
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What other people think of me is what matters most.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have lived under the weight of others' opinions. Free me from the fear of man, and let me live honestly before You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.